ground. He thrust it into the mouth of the first Arab and pushed it down until he puked. 'Now', he said, 'Where have you hidden the arms?' Still they shook their heads. Wingate turned to one of the Jews and, pointing to the coughing Arab, said, 'Shoot this man'. The Jew looked at him and hesitated. Wingate said in a tense voice, 'Did you hear? Shoot this man.' The Jew shot the Arab. The others stared in horror at the dead body. The Jewish boys looked in silence. 'Now speak,' said Wingate. They spoke.

The Peel Commission 1937

Key question
Why did the British decide on, and later reject, the partition of Palestine?

In 1937, the British government set up an inquiry, led by Lord Peel. In their report, the Peel Commission recommended the **partition** of Palestine into two separate states, one Jewish and the other Arab. The Arabs rejected the plan while the Jews wanted more land than they were allocated under it. The fighting continued and, eventually, with the help of more troops, better weapons and transport, the British forces were able to regain control of Palestine.

By 1939, when the rebellion ended, the British government had given up all further ideas of partition. War was approaching and Britain feared the growth of friendship between Arab leaders and Germany. Britain needed to keep the Arab countries on their side so that oil supplies from the Middle East would continue to reach Britain. The government issued a special report called a **White Paper**. This declared that Britain wanted an independent Palestine within 10 years. This would be neither a Jewish state nor an Arab one, but one in which Arabs and Jews shared responsibility for governing the country. Meanwhile, Britain would continue to rule Palestine. The White Paper also said that Britain would restrict Jewish immigration:

> For each of the next five years a limit of 10,000 Jewish immigrants will be allowed apart from a special quota in the near future of 25,000 refugees as a contribution to the solution of the Jewish refugee problem.
>
> After the period of five years no further Jewish immigration will be permitted unless the Arabs are prepared to agree to it.

Not surprisingly, the Jews were furious.

Key terms

Partition
Division into two or more parts.

White Paper
A government document making recommendations for discussion.

Key dates

Peel Commission recommended partition of Palestine: 1937

British government White Paper: 1939

Summary diagram: British rule in Palestine 1919–39

British rule imposed on Palestine after war

Jewish immigration in 1920s led to:
- Arabs losing land
- outbreaks of Arab–Jewish violence in 1921 and 1929

Nazi anti-Semitism in 1930s contributed to:
- increased Jewish immigration to Palestine
- Arab Rebellion 1936–9 and its suppression by British authorities
- British recommendation to partition Palestine 1937

Approach of Second World War led British to abandon partition and restrict Jewish immigration